Disillusionment (Spring 1966–Spring 1967)

Over the next year, while this mutual need remained, disappointment and then disillusionment grew in both the US and India. American and Indian policymakers increasingly questioned whether the relationship was worth the effort it required.

The Demands of Dependence

Bowles more or less agreed with Jha about the countries' mutual dependence, but Johnson was increasingly unsure about whether India deserved a key role in his China strategy. Some of the president's aides encouraged him to do much more to strengthen India and the fledgling government of Indira Gandhi, who became prime minister following Shastri's death. The president did not agree.[42] India had not been living up to its billing for years, but now its performance was not even living up to his lower expectations. He increasingly thought this was a "one-way deal." He wanted to know, "What can they do to help us?"[43]

Eventually, in February 1966, Johnson approved negotiations for the resumption of economic assistance and defense sales (on credit or commercial terms) on a case-by-case basis. He asked Vice President Hubert Humphrey to convey the hope that India did not overspend on defense. Johnson clarified that in return he did not expect an alliance or "rubber-stamp[ing]" of US foreign policies. He did want Indian officials to refrain from daily denunciations of his Vietnam policy and to try sometimes to defend the US when it was under attack in international forums. The administration also hoped Delhi would use its International Control Commission role to "promote peace."[44] Visiting India, Humphrey told Gandhi that the US did not want Indian "endorsement" on Vietnam, but publicly throwing "dead cats at the US" was highly unhelpful. She expressed "deep concern" about China's aggressiveness. He responded that the US remained committed to India's security, but also pointed out that Delhi needed to think about what it could or would do if China attacked the US in Vietnam.[45]

On Vietnam, Shastri had told Johnson that India did not have enough influence or ties with North Vietnam to involve itself directly, and he had talked with Soviet premier Alexei Kosygin about the matter without much